neem tree in our cattle-pasture and laying it out to dry. Pedanna said, "Making it out of poovarasu wood would be really good. It's a fine-grained wood, without knots. And glossy and strong too."

Our elder sister said, "All these are light-coloured woods. Ugly to look at! After a while, we'll begin to even detest them. I'm saying it will be best to make it the colour of ripe sugarcane or dark like sesame oilcake. But it's your wish…" The vision of a highly comfortable chair—in black wood with a mirror-like gleam, with perfectly shaped front legs, and curved back legs, yawning languorously, to match the recline of the chair—flashed before our eyes.



Everyone felt that she was right. So it was arranged for two chairs to be made immediately, one for us and the other for Maamanaar.

When the two chairs arrived, we didn't know which one to keep and which to send to Maamanaar. If you looked at one, you didn't need to see the other—they were like Rama-Lakshmana. We kept one and sent the other to Maamanaar. We had a doubt: had we sent the better one to him?

One by one, we took turns to sit on the chair. Never felt like getting up from it. But had to because others too had to be given a chance. Pedanna sat and exclaimed appreciatively, "Ah…ha!" He ran his hands over the arms of the chair. He sat cross-legged on it. Athai said, "We have to stitch a cover for it. Otherwise it will get soiled."

My little sister and brother fought over it frequently. She would shout at him, "You've been sitting on it for so long, get up. I want to sit now."

" Ayyo, I've just sat down. Look at her, Amma," he would say, his face puckering, as if about to cry.

The news of the arrival of our chair spread like fire around the village. People—children and adults —arrived in **hordes** to see the chair. A few even stroked it. An old man lifted the chair. "Quite heavy. He's made it sturdy," he commended the carpenter.

A few days passed by.

One night, someone knocked on the door. Pedanna, who was sleeping in the inner pial, opened the door. They said that an important person had just died in the village and that they needed the chair.

Since the deceased was also known to us, we too attended the funeral. It was on our chair that they had propped up the eminent person!

Till now in our village they always seated the corpse only on the floor. A grinding stone was laid on the floor and propped up to keep the corpse from rolling away. A gunny sack stuffed with millet straw would be rested against it. Against

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